
“One of the **great names of our history**, one of the greatest **heroes** of our war.”

ULYSSES S. GRANT ON THE DEATH OF THOMAS, 1870

George Henry Thomas was the third most prominent Union general in the Civil War, after Grant and Sherman—a resolute and highly competent military professional. Born in Southampton County, Virginia, Thomas was the middle of nine children and grew up on a plantation of modest proportions. He graduated from West Point 12th out of 42, then served at various posts in Florida, Louisiana, and South Carolina until the War with Mexico broke out in 1846. During the war Thomas met Braxton Bragg, who later recommended him as an artillery and cavalry instructor at West Point. In 1855–60, Thomas was an officer in the famous 2nd U.S. Cavalry, serving in Texas against the Comanches.

Loyal to the Union

In Virginia expectations were high that Thomas would side with his home state when secession came, yet he remained loyal to the Union army. He was with Major General Robert Patterson’s command in the Shenandoah Valley during the First Bull Run campaign, and then transferred to Kentucky where he trained raw volunteers and led them to victory at the Battle of Mill Springs on January 18, 1861. This victory secured eastern Kentucky for the Union and his reward was a division in Major General Don Carlos Buell’s Army of the Ohio.

A tower of strength

Arriving too late at Shiloh, Thomas, now a major general, fought well in the Corinth campaign of 1862. When Buell was slow to stop